

Study Material: Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb must agree with the subject in number and person. The basic principle is: singular subjects need singular verbs; plural subjects need plural verbs. For example:

- My *brother is* a doctor.
 - My *sisters are* teachers.
1. Two or more singular subjects joined by 'and' take a plural verb:
 - *Oil and water do* not mix.
 - *A car and a bike are* the popular means of transportation.
 2. When two singular nouns joined by 'and' together express one idea, the singular verb is used:
 - *Slow and steady wins* the race.
 - *Rice and curry is* my favourite dish.
 3. If two singular subjects are joined with – 'as well as,' 'in addition to,' 'besides,' 'not,' 'with,' 'along with,' 'together with' – the verb agrees with the first subject:
 - The owner *as well as* his servants *is* honest.
 - Diseases *in addition to* poverty and illiteracy *pose* a big challenge in slums.
 - Several other activities *besides* writing *keep* me busy.
 - The teacher *with/ along with* his students *was* present in the programme.
 - The leader *together with* his friends *is* going to prison.
 4. When two subjects are joined with 'not only – but also' the verb agrees with the 2nd subject:
 - *Not only* the students *but also* the teacher *was* asked to give a presentation.
 - *Not only* the master *but also* his attendants *were also* praised.
 5. Two singular subjects connected with – 'or,' 'nor,' 'either – or,' 'neither – nor' – take a singular verb. For example:
 - *Neither* Joy *nor* Sam *is* available.
 - *Either* Vandana *or* Jyoti *is* helping today with stage decorations.
 6. When the subjects of different numbers are connected by 'or,' 'nor,' 'either – or,' 'neither – nor' the plural subject is placed the last and verb is used according to it:
 - *Neither* Aarti *nor* her friends *like* coffee.
 - The minister *or* his officials *have* to take responsibility of the accident.
 7. When subjects of different persons are connected by 'or,' 'nor,' 'either – or,' 'neither – nor', the second person comes first, the third person comes second and the first person comes last. The verb agrees with the subject nearest it:
 - *Neither* she *nor* I *am* going to the festival.

- *Either You or Tinkle has* to do the job.
8. The expressions, ‘many a,’ ‘a great deal of,’ ‘one of the + (plural noun),’ ‘the number of,’ ‘a majority of,’ ‘pair of’ take a singular verb:
- *Many a* new idea *has* come to my mind.
 - *A great deal of* patience *is* required to do this job.
 - *One of the* boys *has* broken the flask.
 - *The number of* books on this subject *is* very small.
 - *A majority of* people *was* in favor of banning smoking.
 - *A pair of* shoes *was* lying on the floor.
9. Some plural nouns showing an amount, a fraction or an element of time are considered singular and take a singular verb:
- *Sixty minutes is* enough to finish this task.
 - *Ten dollars is* a high price to pay.
 - *Two weeks is* a good holiday.
 - *Three fourths of* land *is* barren.
10. The pronouns, ‘anyone,’ ‘anybody,’ ‘everyone,’ ‘everybody,’ ‘someone,’ ‘no one,’ ‘nobody,’ ‘each,’ ‘every,’ ‘neither,’ and ‘either,’ are singular and take a singular verb:
- *Does anyone* else want to come?
 - *Is there anybody* in the room?
 - *Everybody has done* his or her homework.
 - *Someone has left* her book.
 - *There is no one* in the room.
11. Indefinite pronouns – ‘several,’ ‘few,’ ‘both,’ ‘many’ – are used with plural verbs:
- *Several books were lying* on the table.
 - *Both the books require* careful reading.
12. The words ‘here’ and ‘there’ are generally used as adverbs even though they indicate place. In sentences beginning with ‘here’ or ‘there,’ the verb is used according to the real subject that follows it:
- *There are* many difficulties to overcome.
 - *There is* a big problem in his way.
 - *Here are* two apples.
 - *Here comes* Mr. Gupta.
13. Adjectives – ‘much,’ ‘less,’ ‘little,’ – are used with uncountable nouns and take a singular verb:
- *Much of the work has been done.*
 - *It is less of* a problem than I had expected.
 - *A little knowledge is* a dangerous thing.

14. When subjects and verbs are separated by a comma, a clause or a longer phrase, use the verb according to the actual subject:

- *The dress*, I bought on my birthday, *is* really good.
- *All the songs*, recorded by him, *are* really entertaining.

15. Similarly, when the subject of the verb is a relative pronoun, use the verb according to the antecedent of the relative pronoun:

- I am *the person who has* always stood by you.
- *I who am* your friend should have been told about it.